IN THE UNITED STATES DISTRICT COURT
FOR THE SOUTHERN DISTRICT OF WEST VIRGINIA
CHARLESTON DIVISION

JOHN ANTHONY CASTRO, 12 Park Place, Mansfield, TX 76063 Plaintiff, v. SECRETARY OF STATE ANDREW WARNER, 1900 Kanawha Boulevard E, Charleston, WV 25305 DONALD JOHN TRUMP, 1100 S. Ocean Blvd, Palm Beach, FL 33480 Defendants.	)	Civil Action No. 2:23-cv-00598

VERIFIED COMPLAINT FOR DECLARATORY AND INJUNCTIVE RELIEF

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TO THE HONORABLE COURT:

Plaintiff, JOHN ANTHONY CASTRO, *pro se*, files this Verified Complaint for Declaratory and Injunctive Relief against Defendants Secretary of State and Donald John Trump, in strict conformity with Fed. R. Civ. P. 8(a) for Section I "Claim for Relief," and, in support thereof, alleges as follows:

I. CLAIM FOR RELIEF

A. Jurisdiction

1 Because this cause of action arises under Section 3 of the 14th Amendment to the U.S. Constitution, this Court has subject matter jurisdiction over this action pursuant to 28 U.S.C. § 1331.

B. Parties

2 Plaintiff John Anthony Castro is a U.S. citizen and Republican primary presidential candidate (Candidate FEC ID Number P40007320) for the 2024 Presidential Election who currently resides at 12 Park Place in Mansfield, Texas.

3 Defendant Secretary of State is a representative of the state being sued in official capacity.

4 Defendant Donald John Trump is a U.S. citizen and Republican primary presidential candidate (Candidate FEC ID Number P80001571) for the 2024 Presidential Election who currently resides at 1100 South Ocean Boulevard in West Palm Beach, Florida.

5 Defendant Donald John Trump is a nominal defendant.

C. Venue

6 Because Defendant Secretary of State operates in this district, venue is proper in this district pursuant to 28 U.S.C. § 1391(b)(1). Defendant Donald John Trump is a nominal defendant.

D. Entitlement to Relief

7 Because this state permits write-in candidates and their votes to be counted, ballot placement is not legally determinative of the legal inquiry as to whether an individual is a "candidate" under state law. Moreover, the U.S. Constitution, Article 1, Section 4, Clause 1, also known as the

Election Clause, does not apply to Presidential elections and Presidential candidate eligibility. "The Times, Places and Manner of holding Elections for Senators and Representatives, shall be prescribed in each State by the Legislature thereof." The unambiguous and plain language of the clause shows that it is limited to Congressional elections. As such, it is the province of the federal judiciary to determine this federal question with zero involvement from the state.

8 Section 3 of the 14th Amendment created an implied cause of action for a fellow candidate to obtain relief for a political competitive injury by challenging another candidate's constitutional eligibility on the grounds that they engaged in or provided "aid or comfort" to an insurrection.

9 On September 29, 2020, then Commander-in-Chief of the United States Armed Forces issued an executive military order to a paramilitary organization known as the Proud Boys that was led by Chairman Enrique Tarrio when he instructed them on live television to "stand back and standby."

10 On January 6, 2021, after witnessing a large group of Trump supporters violently attacking the United States Capitol to prevent the lawful certification of the 2020 election results with the goal of unlawfully compelling Donald John Trump's inauguration on January 20, 2021 (hereafter referred to as the "January 6th Insurrection"), Defendant Donald John Trump stated on live television, "we love you, you're very special" to the insurrectionists. Defendant Donald John Trump provided the insurrectionists with comfort in the form of words of sympathy.

11 On January 29, 2022, Defendant Donald John Trump publicly stated, "If I run and if I win, we will treat those people from January 6 fairly. We will treat them fairly. And if it requires pardons, we will give them pardons." Defendant Donald John Trump promised the insurrectionists aid in the form of executive pardons for their criminal attempt to unlawfully overturn the 2020 election results.

12 On May 4, 2023, Proud Boys Chairman Enrique Tarrio was convicted of Seditious Conspiracy. Sedition and Insurrection are synonymous terms. In effect, Enrique Tarrio, the individual to whom Defendant Donald John Trump issued an executive military order, was convicted of conspiracy to commit an insurrection.

13 On June 22, 2023, Defendant Donald John Trump hosted a fundraiser for the January 6 insurrectionists thereby assisting in the acquisition of financial aid for their legal bills.

14 Based on these instances and other acts of ratification of the acts of and sympathy with the convicted criminals of the January 6th Insurrection, Defendant Donald John Trump provided "aid or comfort" to an insurrection in violation of Section 3 of the 14th Amendment to the U.S. Constitution and is, therefore, constitutionally ineligible to pursue or hold any public office in the United States.

15 Because Plaintiff is a fellow FEC-registered Republican primary candidate, Plaintiff will suffer an injury that may be redressed by the judiciary with injunctive relief.

E. Demand for Relief

16 Plaintiff John Anthony Castro asks this Court to issue an injunction preventing Defendant Secretary of State from accepting and/or processing Defendant Donald John Trump's ballot access documentation, including, but not limited to, nominating papers and nominating petitions.

17 Plaintiff requests any other relief he may be entitled to at law or equity.

II. SUMMARY OF THE ARGUMENT

18 Because Plaintiff is a Republican Presidential candidate actively competing against Defendant Donald John Trump for the nomination of the Republican Party to pursue the Office of the Presidency in the general election in 2024, Plaintiff has standing to pursue a claim regarding Defendant Donald John Trump's qualifications and eligibility to be a candidate. Section 3 of the 14th Amendment is self-executing thereby providing an implied cause of action directly thereunder to an individual with judicial standing to enforce the provision. Plaintiff's claim is that Defendant Donald John Trump "engaged" in the insurrection with convicted insurrectionist Enrique Tarrio via direct military orders to "stand back and stand by" and provided "aid or comfort" to other insurrectionists in the form of financial fundraising, expressions of sympathy with the insurrectionary movement, and

promises of pardons for those who violently attacked our United States Capitol on January 6, 2021. Because the goal of the insurrection was to thwart the peaceful transfer of power via the Electoral College's certification of the election results and to unlawfully compel the re-inauguration of then-President and current Defendant Donald John Trump, this was indisputably an insurrection that Defendant Donald John Trump previously did and presently continues to provide both aid and comfort to. As such, Plaintiff seeks a declaratory judgment that Defendant Donald John Trump is disqualified under Section 3 of the 14th Amendment. Furthermore, Plaintiff seeks an injunction against Defendant Secretary of State to prevent the acceptance and/or processing of any ballot access documentation of Defendant Donald John Trump for both the primary election and general election.

A. Plaintiff Has Political Competitor Standing

19 Plaintiff John Anthony Castro intends to either appear on the 2024 Republican primary ballot in this state or to file documentation to be a formally recognized write-in candidate in both the primary and general elections. As such, Plaintiff will maintain "standing" throughout the entire course of this litigation until Tuesday, November 5, 2024, at which time standing will have to be reassessed depending on the circumstances as Plaintiff may still have an injury after the election warranting continued review by the federal judiciary.

20 The Constitution limits the jurisdiction of the federal courts to actual cases or controversies.[1] "One element of the case-or-controversy requirement is that [plaintiffs], based on their complaint, must establish that they have standing to sue."[2] The doctrine of standing, "rooted in the traditional understanding of a case or controversy… developed… to ensure that federal courts do not exceed their authority as it has been traditionally understood."[3] "[T]he 'irreducible constitutional minimum' of standing consists of three elements."[4] The "plaintiff must have (1) suffered an injury in

[1] U.S. Const. art. III, § 2, cl. 1, *see also Raines v. Byrd*, 521 U.S. 811, 818 (1997).
[2] *Raines*, 521 U.S. at 818.
[3] *Spokeo, Inc. v. Robins*, 578 U.S. 330 (2016).
[4] *Id.* (quoting *Lujan v. Defenders of Wildlife*, 504 U.S. 555, 560 (1992)).

fact, (2) that is fairly traceable to the challenged conduct of the defendant, and (3) that is likely to be redressed by a favorable judicial decision."[5]

21 The United States Court of Appeals for the D.C. Circuit has recognized the concept of *Political Competitor Standing* on the basis that an injury would logically be diminution of votes traceable to the political competitor and redressable by a court.[6] Political Competitor Standing, however, is only available to plaintiffs who can show that they "personally compete[] in the same arena with the same party."[7] The D.C. Circuit has also held that if a plaintiff can show that he is a "direct and current competitor," then competitor standing must be recognized as a matter of law.[8] The federal judiciary has recognized that a candidate, as opposed to "individual voters and political action groups" would have "standing based upon a 'competitive injury'" if, again, the candidate can show that he "personally competes in the same arena with the same party."[9]

22 Castro is an FEC-registered 2024 Republican Presidential candidate and is currently directly competing against Trump for the Republican nomination for the Presidency of the United States. As such, Castro has political competitor standing to bring this suit.

B. Injunctive Relief

23 The public interest is greatly served by preventing a violation of the United States Constitution. *See Council of Alternative Political Parties v. Hooks*, 121 F.3d 876, 883-884 (3d Cir.

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[5] *Id.*
[6] *See Shays v. FEC*, 414 F.3d 76, 87 (D.C. Cir. 2005).
[7] *Gottlieb v. FEC*, 143 F.3d 618, 621 (D.C. Cir. 1998) (internal quotation marks omitted); *see also Fulani v. Brady*, 935 F.2d 1324, 1327-28 (D.C. Cir. 1991) (holding that presidential candidate did not have "competitor standing" to challenge CPD's tax-exempt status where the candidate was not eligible for tax exempt status); *Hassan v. FEC*, 893 F. Supp. 2d 248, 255 (D.D.C. 2012), *aff'd*, No. 12-5335, 2013 WL 1164506 (D.C. Cir. 2013) ("Plaintiff cannot show that he personally competes in the same arena with candidates who receive funding under the Fund Act because he has not shown that he is or imminently will be eligible for that funding.").
[8] *New World Radio, Inc. v. FCC*, 294 F.3d 164, 170 (D.C. Cir. 2002).
[9] *Hassan*, 893 F. Supp. 2d at 255 n.6 (D.D.C. 2012) (emphasis added) (quoting *Gottlieb*, 143 F.3d at 621).

1997) (stating that in "the absence of legitimate, countervailing concerns, the public interest clearly favors the protection of constitutional rights.").

24 The United States Constitution conferred onto individuals like Plaintiff John Anthony Castro with the right to not have to politically compete with someone that either engaged in or merely provided aid or comfort to an insurrection or insurrectionists. This is a new constitutional right not previously recognized by the federal judiciary.

1. Actual Sustained Harm and Threat of Further Injury Outweighs the Harm that an Injunction Would Cause Defendant

25 Plaintiff John Anthony Castro's sustained harm and ongoing harm outweighs the harm an injunction would cause Defendant Donald John Trump. We cannot ignore the intent of the framers of the Fourteenth Amendment. For they saw with their own eyes what men like Defendant Donald John Trump can do to the seams that bind our nation. They foresaw that men like Defendant Donald John Trump would not be satisfied until they spilled the blood of every American citizen that disagreed with them.

26 Defendant Donald John Trump has promised to imprison his political enemies if re-elected President of the United States.

27 The entire nation knows that Defendant Donald John Trump provided aid and comfort to the January 6th Insurrection. The only remaining question is whether the federal judiciary has the courage to do the right thing.

2. Injunction Will Not Disserve the Public Interest

28 The public has an interest in preserving our Republic from a pro-insurrection candidate who is constitutionally disqualified and presently both a state and federal criminal defendant facing over 300 years in state and federal prison.

29 If a denial of temporary injunctive relief will moot the issue given the time-sensitive nature of the circumstances, it has the "practical effect" of denying preliminary injunctive relief and is,

therefore, appealable under 28 U.S.C. § 1292(a)(1) as of right. *See Carson v. Am. Brands, Inc.*, 450 U.S. 79, 83 (1981).

Respectfully submitted,

By: /s/John Anthony Castro
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Plaintiff *Pro Se*

September 4, 2023.

VERIFICATION

I, John Anthony Castro, declare as follows:

1. I am the plaintiff in the present case, a U.S. citizen, and an FEC-registered Republican primary presidential candidate (Candidate FEC ID Number P40007320) for the 2024 Presidential Election.

2. I intend to either appear on the 2024 Republican primary ballot in this state or to file documentation to be a formally recognized write-in candidate in both the primary and general elections. As such, I will maintain "standing" throughout the course of this litigation.

3. I have personal first-hand knowledge of all of the factual matters set forth in this document, and, if called upon to testify or give oral arguments, I would competently do so.

4. Pursuant to 28 U.S.C. § 1746 and state [sic], I verify under penalty of perjury that the entirety of the foregoing document is true and correct.

Executed on September 4, 2023.

/s/ John Anthony Castro
John Anthony Castro